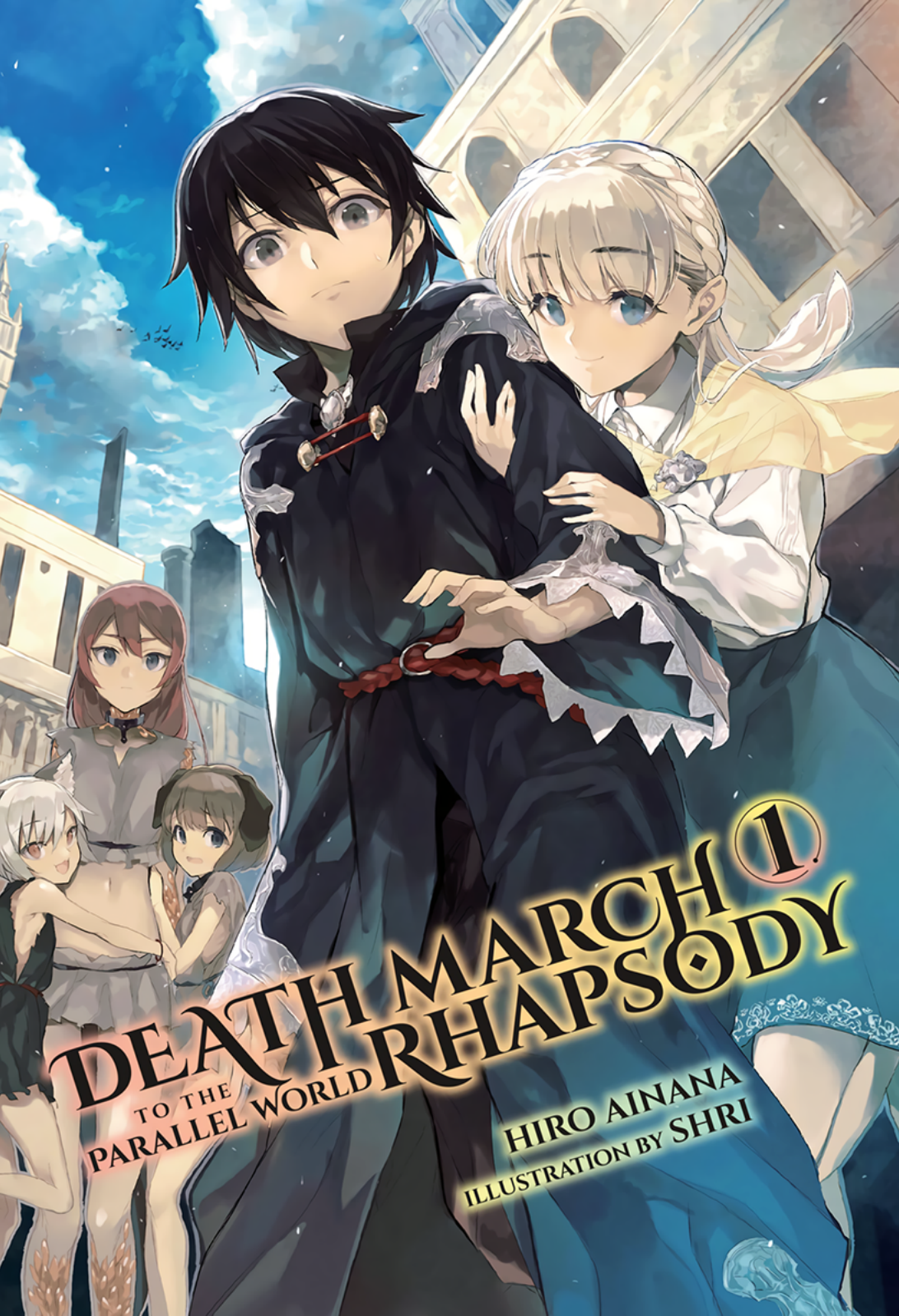




DEATH MARCH ① TO THE PARALLEL WORLD RHAPSODY

HIRO AINANA
ILLUSTRATION BY SHRI



DEATH MARCH
TO THE
PARALLEL WORLD Rhapsody



TAMA

A cat-eared girl. She is lost in the labyrinth when Satou finds her.



LIZA

A scalefolk girl. She is lost in the labyrinth when Satou finds her.



POCHI

A dog-eared girl. She is lost in the labyrinth when Satou finds her.

SATOU

A programmer who is around thirty years old. He took a nap in the middle of a "death march" at work, but when he woke up, he found himself in a different universe...



ZENA MARIENTEIL

Seventeen years old. She is a magic soldier in the army of the Seiryu County and the daughter of a knight.

“Um...are you sure it's okay
for me to take it?”

“Of course. It would
trouble me if you didn't.”



Death March
to the
Parallel World
Khapsody

PROLOGUE

Death March to Disaster

.....

Level Up

.....

Seiryuu City

.....

A City Stroll

.....

Date

.....

Labyrinth

.....

Back to the Surface

.....

Afterword

.....

DEATH MARCH
TO THE
PARALLEL WORLD Rhapsody

1

★ ★ ★
HIRO AINANA
ILLUSTRATION BY SHRI

YEN
UN
NEW YORK

PROLOGUE DEATH MARCH TO DISASTER

Stars streak across the sky.

Dozens and dozens of them.

Have you ever seen a shooting star?

I'm sure many people have. Maybe you've been captivated by their fleeting beauty or made a wish on one as it fell through the night sky.

But have you ever watched a meteorite rip through the heavens toward the surface? Have you seen it tear the sky to pieces with a thunderous roar, crashing into the ground with a terrifying impact?

Maybe some of you have seen something like it on TV or on the Internet somewhere. But even then, I'm sure nobody ever thought they wanted to see a meteor shower up close, hurtling down all around them.

And yet, at this very moment, I'm watching more than a hundred falling rocks pour down right before my eyes, one after the other.

No—I shouldn't say it so passively, as if it's someone else's problem. Because I'm the one responsible for this disaster in the first place.

Because of a choice I thoughtlessly made just ten minutes ago,

a meteor shower is gouging out the ground. The meteorites make landfall everywhere, from a few hundred feet away from me to the enormous canyon in the distance, crushing all the enemies within that large radius.

The dots on the radar in the corner of my field of vision disappear like a bothersome stain being washed away. I can't see it from here, but most likely, countless lives are being snuffed out at each meteorite's point of impact.

And shortly after each one disappears into the earth, I hear the sound of the impact and feel a tremor under my feet. And then, just as a massive tidal wave of debris is about to reach me—

Suddenly, a searing pain hits me like the wrath of God. It's as if my skull is breaking open and my body is splitting apart.

As the pain stops, my body is lost in the dust cloud.



Let me rewind a bit.

I was working overtime on a day off in a last-ditch effort to get a long-overdue project completed in time for its final deadline. As a programmer for a subcontracting company, I work on outsourced projects like PC and smartphone games that are commissioned by larger companies.

However shady our company might be, one person never has more than two projects at a time. But because of too many last-minute changes and bugs, the younger programmer assigned to this game had gone AWOL right before it was due! What a loser!

In fact, the job turnover rate here was so high, Junior and I had been the only two programmers in the entire company. Since there was no time to find a last-minute replacement, I got stuck

finishing up his projects in addition to my own.

“All right—entry of all classes’ input/output and comments, complete. Now I just need to let the auto-documenter prep the docs from the source code and draw up a correlation diagram, and then I can get down to some serious debugging.”

I stretched a little, cracking my neck. Looking around, it seemed like all hands were on deck—you never would have guessed it was a holiday. Unfortunately, this was par for the course at my workplace.

At the next desk over, the supervisor for debug commissions was grumbling as he worked, but nobody paid him any mind. Who had the time? The game designers and planners nearby worked alone in silence, all with the same dead, vacant eyes.

By the time I had made coffee and returned to my desk, my PC had finished its processes, and the data needed for debugging was complete. Without this data, it was no wonder my former coworker had done such a terrible job. *I guess it's pointless to complain about Junior when they tossed him into the fray without any on-the-job training, huh? There were four programmers working here only half a year ago when he started, and now there's just me, so I think that says more about this company than anything...*

“Mr. Sa... Er, Mr. Suzuki—the client is complaining that WW is too hard for beginners and asking us to fix it... What should we do?” I looked over my shoulder to see Mr. Tubs, the director and lead designer, looking at me helplessly—as always.

I heard you start to call me Satou, pal. Can't you at least get my name right? I've been on the team for over six months! And why do you look sort of happy about even more problems? I don't get why so many developers are masochists.

WW is short for *War World*, a PC browser game we've been

developing in earnest for some time. It's a strategy game with some social media elements, set in a fantasy world.

"Didn't I tell them that if we make it any easier, their target demographic won't play it...?" We'd spent countless meetings with the client deciding on this difficulty level. I guess all those pointless meetings really were, well, pointless. Great.

"Well, they shot this down before, but what if we added a bonus feature where new players get the ability to find all the enemies on the map, plus a three-use-only bomb spell that can wipe them out? We could give them an extra-special title or something if they get through without using it, so the more-skilled gamers can have an incentive not to activate it."

"We don't have much time, so let's go with that. Set it up, would you please, Suzuki?" Mr. Tubs was as carefree with his requests as ever.

"Wait a minute. I'm working on debugging the smartphone MMO right now, so can you get the okay from the client first? If we just stick it in there without asking, we won't have time to change it later if they don't like it."

"All righty, I'll call them right away!" Mr. Tubs waddled away into the smoking area, cell phone in hand.

I resumed my work, grumbling to myself all the while. Before long, Mr. Tubs gave me the thumbs-up, and it got later and later as I continued working, staving off my hunger with junk food.

Correcting the countless mistakes in Junior's work would take up most of the night before I could finally leave the rest to the debugging team.

What was the name of that game again? Since we always referred to it as "the MMO" or "that RPG," I had forgotten its actual title.

...*Oh, right*—“Freedom Fantasy World.” I guess we’d avoided calling it that because it was confusingly similar to *WW*’s old title, *Fantasy War World*. But I did remember that the old spec documents were always labeled *FFW* and so on. Eventually, they took the *Fantasy* out of *WW*’s title, and the RPG’s name, which had apparently been temporary, was switched to *Freedom Fantasy Life*, with *FFL* as the new abbreviation. So there was no longer any real cause for confusion, but by then it was already too late.

“Suzuki, we’ve got a bug report from the group checking Storage.”

“What is it this time? If it’s about the infinite free items, I already took care of it.”

“No, that was a problem with the inventory in *FFL*. This time it’s an item duplication bug in *WW*, they said. Could you take a look at the attachment we sent you?”

“Okay. Damn, duplication bugs are always tough to get rid of...”

Ugh. Working on two projects at once is so complicated. By the way, “Storage” doesn’t refer to any external storage or hard drives—it’s the name of *WW*’s inventory system.

I continued my work correcting errors in *WW*, dealing with each bug report as it came in from the debug team. At some point in the process, Mr. Tubs sent an e-mail asking me to remove the capacity limitations from *WW*’s Storage for the beta test.

He e-mailed because he doesn’t want me to yell at him in person, the bastard. I’m definitely gonna make him buy me dinner or something after all this.

The *FFL* debug team needed to check some limitations, too, and asked me to temporarily deactivate the level restrictions.

Shouldn't that be the server group's job? I cursed them out under my breath as I worked. *Man, this is going to be another all-nighter, isn't it?*

The error correction continued well into the morning until, miraculously, we were finally able to deliver the *FFL* app to the client. It definitely wasn't bug-free, but fortunately, an advantage of online distribution is the ultimate last-resort weapon known as the "update patch." I could almost hear the users booing me for thinking it, but I was too tired to care.

I made my corrections to the other team's work for *WW* and sent the program file to Mr. Tubs via intercompany mail. After thirty hours without sleep, it was time for a well-earned nap in the peaceful area underneath my desk.

Go ahead and laugh at this corporate slave. Right now, sleep is justice!



Have you ever heard of lucid dreaming?

It's when you're dreaming, but you're aware you're dreaming.

Right then, I was in a desert wasteland.

Yes, a wasteland. If you can picture the Grand Canyon, that should give you an idea.

How did I know this was a dream? For one thing, I remembered falling asleep under my desk just a few moments ago. For another, there were the four icons in the bottom-right corner of my field of vision along with the gadget labeled **Menu** and the radar display in the top right. It was the interface from *WW*, the game I had been working on not long ago.

However! This wasn't the first time I'd taken a nap during a death march and found myself working even in my dreams. That I was doing it in a desert instead of the office or my room was a little weird, but it was probably just because the room I was sleeping in was really dry or something.

The scent of the parched earth tickled my nose. A dream where I could smell things... That was unusual. Through a little trial and error, I figured out that I could open the menu just by thinking about it. To my amusement, some kind of bug prevented me from actually touching it with my hand. Luckily, I could operate it with my mind, too.

The menu items seemed to be a mix of *FFL* and *WW*, but I guess you couldn't exactly expect dreams to be consistent. My character name was Satou, as usual. People often call me that by mistake, so it's what I generally name my test characters. My status and such were standard for a new level 1 character, and my equipment consisted of the protein bar, wallet, cell phone, and other things I'd had on me when I fell asleep.

Typical half-assed dream logic.

As I surveyed my surroundings, I saw one area where the ground cut off completely. Figuring it was a cliff or something, I headed toward it.

Clearly, I was pretty high up: I was standing on the edge of a steep drop-off that went down at least three hundred feet. Similar pillars of high land rose up from all over the wasteland. At the bottom, the same reddish-brown earth stretched as far as the eye could see.

In the distance, I could see some kind of rift, possibly a canyon. I tried to check it on the map, but everything outside my immediate area was blank. Assuming this dream had a "fog of war" system like *WW* did, I would only be able to see areas I'd ex-

plored. A label in the upper left said **Valley of Dragons**, so maybe that's what the rift was? I squinted as best I could, but I didn't see anything that looked like a dragon.

Instead, I saw something very different.



It was emerging from the shadows of the nearest cliff, kicking up a cloud of dust as it came. Like a cavalry charge in a fantasy film.

My eyes instinctively fell on the four icons in the bottom-right corner of my vision: one that read **Search Entire Map** and three that read **Meteor Shower**. The emergency skills for beginners that I'd come up with after the meeting with Mr. Tubs. Driven by a vague sense of unease, I selected the **Search Entire Map** icon.

The radar automatically located any enemies, and a cluster of red dots confirmed the approaching group was hostile. Since the radar's scope was limited, I opened up the bigger map to check their configuration.

The advancing army was a group of high-level enemies. There were so many of them, the map's entire upper half was flooded with red.

...Isn't this...a bit over the top? There's way too many.

The approaching band was labeled **Elite Lizardmen**. There were around three hundred of them, most about level 50. An unarmed level 1 player like me definitely wouldn't stand a chance.

When the group was less than two thousand feet from the cliff, their marching suddenly halted. I ducked behind a rock, out of sight, and peered out at them.

They seemed like some kind of mounted army, but it was no ordinary cavalry. I could tell their mounts weren't horses, but the dust obscured my view too heavily to determine much else.

One of the riders broke away and came closer to my hiding spot, finally giving me a clearer look. The mount wasn't a horse at all but some kind of velociraptor-like dinosaur, and the armored rider was not a human but a lizardman.

“●●●●●●●●!●●●●●●●●●●●●●●●●●●●!●●●●●●●●●●●●●●!”

The lizardman was shouting something in a language I didn't understand, but there was no question that he seemed to have figured out I was here. I guess I could chalk that up to absurd dream logic, too.

He seemed to wait a moment for my reply. When none came, he apparently grew tired of waiting and took up a longbow, aimed it right at me, and drew the bowstring back with a powerful arm. The outline of his body briefly glowed red, but I had no time to worry about that.

The lizardman let his arrow fly, and it cut through the air, whistling straight toward me. Yes, completely straight—it moved in a perfect line, seemingly untouched by gravity. In that instant, I resigned myself to dying in my dream, but the arrow only grazed my cheek as it flew past.

My face felt hot, as if it had been burned. Unconsciously, I put my hand to my cheek and felt something slippery. Looking down, I saw that my fingers were stained red, just as I'd feared.

I touched my tongue to the fresh blood and tasted iron... *Is this really a dream...?* The question sprang unbidden to my mind.

A thunderous sound like torrential rain interrupted my thoughts. The army was firing on me, their arrows raining down

in a perfect arc. I quickly slid into a hollow in the rock—well, I tumbled into it clumsily, to be more accurate.

Before I had a chance to catch my breath, a hail of arrows pierced the ground where my body had been just moments before. The first shafts to land snapped and scattered as the arrows behind them struck home. Eyeing the razor-sharp arrowheads, I shivered as if my back had been doused in cold water.

The arrows accumulated within thirty feet of my hiding place. Those lizardmen were talented marksmen, but I had no time to waste on admiring them.

The only thing on my mind was fear.

Those of you who have been chased by monsters in your dreams will probably understand how I felt.

I had very few options. I could stay there squatting beneath the rock and die, try to run away during a break in the cascade of arrows, or *fight back*.

I selected one of the three **Meteor Shower** icons that were still in the corner of my vision. The icon vanished, leaving behind a temporary trace.

But that was all.

“Oh, come on! Are you telling me the command implementation isn’t working yet?”

As if to further fan my panic, another wave of arrows rained down. Slowly but surely, the barrage was whittling away my hiding place. “Just how strong are these arrows, anyway? Are these guys Robin Hood’s merry band or something?”

Cursing, I selected the two remaining **Meteor Shower** icons. But again, the symbols only disappeared, with no other effect.

One of the arrows finally broke through the rock and grazed my shoulder.

“Damn it! I’m gonna die because of a bug? What kind of sick bad ending is this?” I grumbled, but my anxious complaints soon faded to a weak murmur.

Why? Because I had spotted countless meteorites breaking through the clouds, crashing down.

I stared stupidly at the sight.

Thanks for your patience—we’re finally back to the scene where all this started.

Real name: Ichirou Suzuki.

Character name: Satou.

This is how my life in another world began.

LEVEL UP

Hello, Satou here. Like a typical Japanese worker ant, I've always spent my days neck-deep in my work, but I don't think it ever wore me down so much that I wished I could run away to somewhere else. I was busy, but I felt like my work was worth doing. It's true, I swear!

The pain I felt right before that dust cloud overtook me seemed to have knocked me out for about two hours. The dust had probably been a consequence of all those meteorites hitting the earth, I figured.

The menu displayed the time in a simple format in the corner of my vision. How convenient.

I strained to move my body, which was half-buried in dirt.

Huh? I can't get up...

It felt sort of like when you can't get out of bed on a winter morning. I could move my hands a little, but it was difficult to do much more than sluggishly wiggle my fingers.

CLANK.

The metallic sound shook me out of my half-conscious state. "No way...", I muttered, but deep down I was already sure what it must be. The lizardman who had fired the first arrow before.

As if to confirm my suspicions, a single red dot came into view on my radar. The lizardman on my still-open map screen was the only enemy left alive. How could he have survived all three of

those ridiculous meteor attacks? I didn't think that was possible. Maybe he had avoided the bulk of the strikes by being closer to me than the others?

"I guess I lose this round, huh?" I grumbled. I was somewhat frustrated, but for the most part the lethargic state of my body seemed to have dragged my mind down into resignation as well.

CLANK.

But when I saw the enemy appear at the top of the cliff, that apathy of a player who'd just lost a strategy game vanished completely. The lizardman was bleeding from all over his body, staining the remains of his tattered blue armor red. He spat out a spear he'd had clenched in his teeth onto the cliff and hauled himself forward.

At that moment, his gaze fell on me and refused to break away. My arms and legs shook pathetically. I've had dreams before where I wanted to run away and couldn't move, but I've never dreamed anything that made me tremble so much.

Using the spear as a cane, the warrior shambled toward me, dragging along his broken leg. The thing's body was absolutely covered in wounds. If I'd reacted a little sooner, I might have been able to catch him by surprise with a body slam and knock him off the edge of the cliff—but it was too late for that now.

Despite his battered state, the lizardman's eyes were still burning for a fight. He definitely wanted to kill me. He pulled a sword from the scabbard at his waist—and tossed it at my feet. The sudden movement knocked off a piece of his armor and sent it clattering to the ground.

Now that he'd gotten this close to me, the smell of blood was so strong that I nearly gagged. It would have been far too realistic, if not for the HP gauge floating to the right of the lizardman's head. Underneath was the label **Lizardman: Level 50.**

It seemed to be some kind of augmented reality (AR) feature resembling the ones used nowadays in smartphone games and the like. “Is this supposed to be a game?” I grunted, trying to trick my limbs into moving. For some reason, my body felt a little lighter as I did so.

“●●●●!●●●!”

I had no idea what the lizardman was saying to me, but I could guess. “You want me to take this sword and fight?” Barely recovered, I struggled to get my body to move, reaching for the sword. As silly as it might seem, considering I was dreaming, the fear I felt was completely real.

I gripped the weapon as if grasping at a straw. At that moment, for whatever reason, it didn’t occur to me to beg for my life.

“●●●●!”

My mind raced. I had never taken any kind of fencing or kendo lessons. I hadn’t even lifted a hoe on a farm or used a mallet to make mochi on New Year’s Eve. So my only experience with a blade was what I’d seen in anime and manga and stuff like that, with no actual bearing in reality.

“●●●●!”

I grasped the sword tight with both shaking hands and desperately planted my feet. The lizardman sneered as he readied his spear. Unlike my fake swordsmanship, my opponent’s posture showed a high level of mastery.

The word he kept repeating is difficult to describe—I might spell it out as *mokuugwa* or *makueuga*. Of course, I had no idea what it meant.

“●●●●!” As he shouted, he jabbed the glowing red spear into my shoulder. It hurt—a lot. I’ve heard people say you feel heat more than pain with a stab wound, but no, it was pretty

much just pain. It was unbearable. My mind was too focused on my shoulder to come up with any sort of action to take.

Pulling the spear out of me, the lizardman then stabbed at my leg as if toying with me. As the spear pierced my thigh, I was struck with a fresh wave of agony and toppled unceremoniously onto my backside.

Considering how pathetic I was, I wouldn't have been surprised if I'd passed out from the pain at that point, but instead, for some strange reason I stopped feeling it. Maybe it was my imagination, but my fear seemed to be fading, too. Perhaps I was so scared, my emotional limiter had snapped?

My arms and legs stopped shaking, and I was finally able to think straight. The HP gauge I could see by my opponent's head was nearly zero, but I doubted I could fight him and win. If I tried coming at him with my sword, surely he'd easily counter my attack and put a quick end to things by slashing my throat.

Luckily, it looked like my enemy's movements were as pained as mine. I had to create some kind of opening while he was tormenting me and make a break for it.

As I stood up, I grabbed a fistful of the dry soil. Throwing dirt in an opponent's eyes might be cheap, but I didn't have the luxury of a fair fight right now. I watched the lizardman carefully and struck his spear with my sword just as he drew back. I must have underestimated my remaining strength, because the shove threw him off-balance.

Now's my chance!

I flung the dirt at his face with all my might. It scattered in midair, but enough of it still reached the creature's face. Unfortunately, my opponent was a step ahead of me—he defended himself by throwing an arm up in front of his eyes.

Damn it, you're supposed to be mortally wounded! But at least his arm was blocking his vision. Aiming for his legs, I swung my weapon and let go, flinging it forward. But I had apparently swung too hard—it flew toward the lizardman's torso instead.

I had planned to run away the moment I released the sword, but the scene unfolding before my eyes stopped me in my tracks.

“Huh?!”

The sword had left my hands with shocking speed and cut right through the lizardman's middle, dividing him in half. Blood gushed out of his severed body.

Oh god... I'm not good with gory stuff. And I'd never seen anything so gruesome before, not even in movies.

“He's disappearing...” Just like an enemy in a video game, the lizardman's corpse was fading away. However, the traces of blood left behind were proof that the battle had been no illusion.

I sat down hard on the ground and looked up at the sky, then finally took a deep breath. *Whew! This dream is exhausting... If I have to dream something so realistic, couldn't I be on a tropical beach or something, making out with hot girls in bikinis?*



I took off my polo shirt to try to treat my wounds. It was chilly, but not so much that I'd catch a cold. Putting it into Storage, I used my T-shirt to wipe off the blood.

Strangely enough, I'd stopped bleeding. I would've expected a stab wound from a spear to last a lot longer. When I rubbed at the hardened blood with my finger, it fell away in clumps. Underneath it was perfectly clear skin—not even so much as a scar.

The pain had stopped, too, I realized. Maybe this gamelike dream had a system where you healed automatically after clearing a mission? I opened the status screen to confirm; sure enough, my HP had been fully restored. On closer inspection, in fact, my maximum HP had increased. Not only that, but my level had jumped from 1 to 310!

The crazy speed of that sword throw before must have been because of my high level. My strength, as well as all my other stats, had been raised all the way to the max value.



I must have leveled up so much because of all the enemies I defeated with those Meteor Showers. Wanting to see the aftermath of the Meteor Showers, I looked over the edge of the cliff. The scenery below was terrifying. A veil of dust still hung in the air, obscuring the wasteland, but the ground I could make out through it was dotted with craters. The area where the army had stood was thoroughly pockmarked, too.

My assumption had probably been right: The lizardman I'd fought before must have escaped a direct hit from the meteorites because he was some distance away from the rest of the group. Since he had still been on the verge of death, the shock waves alone must have been incredibly powerful.

As for the canyon in the distance, the Valley of Dragons, it seemed like a good deal of the area had caved in. It looked less like the aftermath of a magical in-game attack and more like the battered surface of the moon. Well, that was only to be expected if a small pocket of land was hammered with three attacks of more than a hundred meteorites each, I guess.

The scenery looked like something from a movie, so maybe that was why it didn't feel real. *Ah, right—this is a dream anyway...isn't it?* It was too vivid for a dream, yet far too strange to be real life. If anything, it seemed more likely I was inside a game.

Well, if this is a game, you'd think beating all those enemies would trigger some sort of event.

Trying to gather more information, I looked at the log screen. It started with the message WELCOME TO OUR WORLD. Normally, this would seem like a pretty significant statement, but since *FFL* starts with that same message, I skimmed past it.

The log showed what icons I had used, the defeats of the lizardmen and other enemies, and the defeat of some dragons

that had apparently been the former rulers of the Valley of Dragons. It also included notifications of level-ups and the acquisition of various titles and then, finally, my victory over the last lizardman. After this was a line that said SOURCE: CONQUERED THE VALLEY OF DRAGONS, but I had no idea what that meant and simply ignored it.

Next was a log of all the spoils I'd gained in battle. Even the corpse of that lizardman was listed among the loot, which would explain why it had disappeared. *Am I supposed to become a necromancer now, or what?*

Remembering my opponent's graphic death, I made a Graveyard folder in my Storage and stowed all the corpses in there. After a moment's thought, I gazed at the folder and clasped my hands together in a brief prayer.

As I continued checking my status, I noticed that those emergency skills for beginners that I'd used earlier had been registered in the magic menu. I hadn't been able to access that menu, but now it seemed I could use the new magic skills on the list if I selected and enabled them.

I wish this dream didn't have all these annoying systems.

Testing out Search Entire Map wouldn't necessarily prove its effectiveness, so I decided to try out the Meteor Shower spell. A quick check of the map confirmed that I was alone, so it shouldn't be a problem. I had to test it out while I had the chance, lest I find myself in a dilemma and try to use it only to get a NOT ENOUGH MP message or something.

I selected **Meteor Shower** in the magic menu and chose **use**. Perhaps because there weren't any enemies on the map, a pop-up appeared that said **Please select a target**. *I guess I have to mark a target area for destructive magic, like in WW.* I picked a site about three times as far away as the Valley of Dragons.

Apparently, this was good enough, because my MP meter decreased immediately. I felt like something was being drawn out of my body, much more intensely than when I had used Search Entire Map. This hadn't happened the first time I used these skills, probably because I wasn't using my own magic power then. This time, my MP went down by a thousand points or so, about a third of my total.

I looked up at the sky. No meteorites yet. Going by the first time, they should be showing up any moment now. Finally, I saw something burst through the clouds like before, but...

What's going on? They're HUGE!

The boulders streaking toward the ground were almost a hundred times the size of the rocks I'd summoned before. No, considering how far away they were, they must have been even bigger. Before I could start wondering why, I instinctively broke into a run. Away from the hail of meteorites, obviously!

Meteorites probably wasn't the right word for these giant chunks of rock tearing through the atmosphere. A wave of sound bore down on me so hard my skin rippled, and I ran even faster, shrieking at a volume that rivaled the thunderous roar. I have no idea what I actually screamed, if anything. I do remember the incredibly strong air resistance, like I was running through water.

As I fled, I eventually noticed that I was going way too fast, but it was too late to hit the brakes. I braced my legs with all my strength, but I still couldn't stop. The physical stress shredded my sneakers like scraps of paper. My heel smashed through a rock, and when my hands hit the ground, my fingers carved out ten grooves in the stone.

But even that wasn't enough to stop my movement, and I went flying off the edge of the cliff into the air. Since I'd managed to kill most of my momentum, I was able to land on a protruding

rock formation about fifteen feet down.

Man, that was three times scarier than a free fall.

Periodic tremors in the earth made it impossible to stand. I clung to the protrusion, not wanting to fall all the way down. A tidal wave of dirt, like a muddy river, flooded across the ground. Occasionally, I'd see rocks the size of a car rolling along with the dust, sending a shiver up my spine.

Once the earth had stopped shaking, I attempted to climb back up the escarpment to see the results of the Meteor Shower. The air was still hazy with debris, so I wrapped my T-shirt around my face in lieu of a mask. It smelled of blood a little, but it was better than breathing in dust and having a coughing fit.

When I pressed my fingers into the cliff face, they made little finger-size holes. The rock didn't seem to be particularly brittle, so I was able to climb up with relative ease.

Upon reaching the top again, I remembered that I was now barefoot, so I searched through my Storage. I found some sandals and tried taking them out, but they were covered in blood, so I hastily put them back.

If I have to use something bloody anyway, it might as well be my own blood. I took the red-stained polo shirt out of Storage, ripped it in two, and wrapped each half around one of my feet. Not exactly stylish, but it would do for now.

When I raised my head and peered into the distance, I saw something that looked like a mushroom cloud. Moving to the edge of the cliff, I could make out a red light on the surface. Was it lava that had burst out from underground, maybe? It might have just been fire, but since I couldn't tell from here what the situation was, I decided to look at the map.

I switched the map display from 2-D to 3-D. Judging by the

fact that my target marker was now floating in midair, the ground must have collapsed considerably. The land around where the meteors had struck was warped and distorted, too.

Gazing at the mushroom cloud, I silently opened the magic menu and switched the Meteor Shower spell from **enabled** to **disabled**, rendering it unusable.

This spell is dangerous. If I used it over and over, I'd turn right into a demon lord. They say a wise man stays away from danger, so I was better off keeping it sealed away.

The reason it was so much stronger than the first time was the increase in my level or my intelligence stat, or so I figured. And it looked like my other attributes had powered up, too. That I was able to make holes in the rock with my fingers was probably thanks to a heightened strength stat, and my ability to endure the recoil from that was probably my higher stamina. And that mad dash that was fast enough to create air resistance must have been my agility stat at work.

I picked up a pebble and fiddled with it experimentally, but luckily, it seemed like I was able to control my new strength perfectly. I didn't feel any stronger than usual as I held it then rolled it around between my fingers. But when I tried for a moment to use enough force to break it, it crumbled in my hand.

At one point, I'd accidentally sneezed while holding the pebble, but I didn't crush it or anything. That was a relief.

Maybe it was all the dust blowing around, but the weather was starting to look dodgy, so I found a tent in my spoils and set it up to take a break. Munching on a protein bar, I found a Well Bag among my loot, which I used to quench my thirst. Apparently, this was some kind of Magic Item that never ran out of water. Very convenient, but trying to figure out how it worked seemed like it could keep me up at night, so I decided not to think about it

too much.

Rain had started falling at some point, and it seemed unlikely to let up anytime soon. Since I had some time to kill, I decided to check out the rest of my spoils.

Most of the items were damaged to some extent, probably squashed by the meteorites. There were all kinds of tools, equipment, and everyday necessities, but with most of them broken, I made a few dedicated folders and set them aside.

There were tons of gold coins, silver coins, and all manner of jewels, too. I guess it's true that dragons like shiny things. I found all kinds of currency from various places, and I quickly lost interest in sorting through it. The most numerous were the gold coins from someplace called the Flue Kingdom, of which I had more than ten million—a preposterous 303 tons. Maybe the humans there had been forced to make periodic tributes to the dragons?

I don't know if this is a dream or a game or what, but if I find my way to a human civilization, it looks like I won't need to worry about money. I hope there's no bartering system...

Among my Magic Items were all manner of Holy Swords, Divine Blades, and the like, plus something called a Magic Gun. Somewhere in the recesses of my mind, my middle school self was going nuts. All the swords had stupid names like Excalibur and Durandal, but since it was my dream, I guess I had my own subconscious to thank for that.

Possibly as some kind of antitheft measure, the Holy Swords unleashed a static-like shock that damaged me when I pulled them out, so I put them away for the time being. I'd been able to use them for only a minute, but the swords emitted a pretty blue light when I did. The light faded after a brief moment, though, so maybe they just glowed in the dark.

Moving on, I took the Magic Gun out of Storage and fired it ex-